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Examining donor perceived brand equity in a moderating role of brand credibility

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Abstract

Purpose – The research concerning brand credibility of charity brands is scantly examined. The purpose of this paper is to examine the moderating role of brand credibility within the customer-based brand equity model to investigate donor perceived brand equity of charity brands.

Design/methodology/approach – In a cross-sectional research design, a survey-based research strategy is followed to collect data from 448 active Muslim donors in Pakistan. The collected data are analysed by employing confirmatory factor analysis based on Smart PLS 2.0.

Findings – The results indicate that donor perceived brand association, brand awareness and brand loyalty strongly relate to perceived brand equity of charity brands. The brand credibility moderates the relationship between perceived quality, equity and brand loyalty, and equity paths.

Practical implications – The charity brands need to focus on building a strong brand image and reputation to uplift brand credibility which can be achieved by offering training programmes addressing various social causes such as HIV and Cancer prevention.

Originality/value – The proposed moderating effects of brand credibility and its application to charity brands operating in an Asian Muslim country context are unique products of this study.

Keywords Pakistan, Brand credibility, Charity brands, Customer-based brand equity (CBBE)

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

The growth of charity brands is threatened by strict governmental regulations and weaker customer–brand relationships (Kashif *et al.*, 2015). The limited funds offered by governments to run charitable organisations also make it necessary to efficiently utilise all available resources to achieve their objectives (i.e. excellent brand management efforts can ensure this efficiency) (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014). It is also notable that donors are not emotionally associated with charity brands that can adversely affect brand loyalty patterns (Sargeant *et al.*, 2008). In this regard, a positive relationship between brand loyalty and consumers' brand associations (mainly based on trust) is pivotal to strengthen brand resonance (Keller, 2016; Saleem *et al.*, 2017). This is achieved by building stronger brands which are preferred by customers and also by establishing brands with a stronger share of heart (i.e. the products and services consumers are willing to buy) among target market(s) (Nowak *et al.*, 2006). However, in this regard, the marketers must understand customers' mind-set – the driving force which may trigger positive outcomes for customers and brands

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(Grisaffe and Nguyen, 2011) in the form of value (i.e. a mutual exchange of long-lasting relationships). A stronger emotional bonding between donors and charity brands can ensure brand loyalty (Michel and Rieunier, 2012). It is notable that positive customer–brand ties are a product of perceived credibility (Lee Thomas *et al.*, 2011). However, recently, researchers revealed questionable brand image of charity brands as a key tension facing charitable organisations (Lee, 2013), which signals a trust deficit between charity brands and key stakeholders.

The trust deficit (potentially an issue of brands credibility) in a relationship, especially between donors and charity brands has the potential to drive brand rejection – a threat for the growth and the survival of charity brands (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014). This entails that consumers would likely to reject less credible brands in an era where they have choices. It is evident that non-profit organisations have overlooked the brand building efforts, especially the emotional bonding with the donors – driving trust deficit (Laidler-Kylander and Simonin, 2009). The contemporary researchers have suggested to aggressively initiate re-branding efforts in the charity sector (Lee and Bourne, 2017) by establishing stronger relationships with donors. The trust deficit in a customer–brand relationship is an issue of brand credibility which is important while managing service brands and is acknowledged as an important area of future investigation in services marketing literature (Hyun Baek and Whitehill King, 2011). The weak consumer–brand relationships in the charity sector are attributed to lack of brand credibility (Laran and Wilcox, 2011; Hyun Baek and Whitehill King, 2011). Furthermore, in an era of economic downturn in Asian context, the brand credibility is highlighted as an effective tool to safeguard brand value (Drewniak and Karaszewski, 2016). This necessitates the measurement of brand equity of charity brands and also advocates the important role of brand credibility in strengthening the donor–brand relationships.

The brand credibility refers to the believability in brand's perceived ability and willingness to continuously address customer-related issues on a consistent basis (Erdem and Swait, 1998). It is a multidimensional construct (Law *et al.*, 1998) with expertise and trustworthiness as sub-dimensions of brand credibility (Spry *et al.*, 2011; Erdem and Swait, 1998). The second-order construct of trustworthiness refers to a firm's willingness to deliver on brand promise, while the expertise is about the ability/motivation to perform a task. So far, the issue of brand credibility has attracted scant attention from charity brand researchers while measuring charity brand equity. Recently, the researchers have examined the credibility of charity organisations, but from an organisational perspective (Rahayu Hijrah Hati and Idris, 2014; Kim *et al.*, 2017) – suggested to investigate brand credibility of charity brands in more detail. The brands which are perceived as credible and have a tradition – a heritage – and are likely to receive stronger donor engagement, satisfaction and loyalty (Curran *et al.*, 2016). Another dominant reason that credibility is important in the services sectors is also by the fact that services are intangible (i.e. cannot be seen or felt before purchase) and hence require a significant amount of consumers' believability to minimise their risk perceptions to trigger purchase (Brady *et al.*, 2005). It is attributed to stronger brand credibility as perceived by customers. This also applies to charity brands where consumers are likely to reject brands with weaker credibility (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014). Above all, charity brands support consumer welfare (Kashif and De Run, 2015), hence these organisations should survive and grow in an era where poverty and other social and health-related issues are increasing.

Brand credibility is the perceived believability of whether a given brand contains the ability and willingness to continuously deliver its promises to customers (Erdem and Swait, 2004). A stronger faith by consumers signals higher levels of brand credibility which ultimately influences their purchase intention and enhances perceptions of quality and trust (Hyun Baek and Whitehill King, 2011). More recently, brand trust is highlighted as an antecedent to repurchase intentions among customers of service brands (Saleem *et al.*, 2017). These theoretical issues have stronger relevance to the pragmatic issues facing charity brands. The charity brands are facing challenges such as the lack of donor trust, limited amount of funds available to support social causes and poor brand image, which may drive brand rejection among donors (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014). A stronger loyalty pattern can be developed by integrating brand credibility into the charity brand equity measurement model. This is in accordance with the suggestions made by Erdem and Swait (1998), who proposed that brand equity can be enhanced by imparting the element of believability into the brand equity measurement model. The construct also lacks empirical evidence which necessitates a careful re-examination of marketing matrices which aim at enhancing brand equity of charity organisations. For that purpose, we selected CBBE model – a framework widely employed by marketing researchers to measure brand equity of firms (Kuhn *et al.*, 2008).

There are few research gaps which justify the theoretical and contextual contribution of this study. First, in an effort to advance theory, marketing researchers suggested to employ an integrated approach to examine brand equity measurement (Brodie, 2009; Keller, 2016). This entails that novel constructs should be integrated to enrich the existing frameworks. Furthermore, it is believed that service marketing researchers and brand management scholastic in particular should focus on the relevance of theory to improve management practices (Brodie and De Chernatony, 2009) which can help to counter the brand identity issues faced by charity organisations (Lee and Bourne, 2017). The brand credibility is scantly studied so far (Laran and Wilcox, 2011; Hyun Baek and Whitehill King, 2011). The contemporary researchers have not only investigated organisational credibility (Rahayu Hijrah Hati and Idris, 2014; Kim *et al.*, 2017), but also suggested to further examine the issues of brand credibility of charity brands – a call addressed through this study.

The researchers advocated to frame brand credibility as a moderator to advance marketing theory and practice (Haynes *et al.*, 2014), which is still missing, especially in the context of charity brands. On the other side, the CBBE model is criticised as it lacks comprehensiveness to help marketers to counter challenges which brands are facing in different sectors, to include charity and non-profit sectors (Kuhn *et al.*, 2008). The traditional CBBE model is used by charity brand researchers to examine brand equity (Cronin-Gilmore *et al.*, 2014); however, scholars call for more research studies to enrich the brand equity measurement frameworks (Pike, 2013). Hence, responding to the calls for more studies to investigate brand building issues faced by charity brands (Lee and Bourne, 2017), with a trust deficit among donors where a likely rejection will occur (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014), is important. The brand credibility (McDougle, 2014), especially its potential as a moderator (to strengthen donor–brand relationships – missed by researchers while empirically examining brand equity of charity organisations) (Juntunen *et al.*, 2013) – has its theoretical value.

Contextually, Pakistan, as a developing country context, is selected where the measurement of charity brand equity will help management policy makers to strengthen donor–brand relationships. There are several reasons which justify the selection of Pakistan as a country in context for this research. Pakistan is an Islamic country – dominantly a Muslim population –and Islam as the dominant religion. The religion Islam provides a complete system of livinghood where *Zakat* is obligatory among Muslims and is being paid at an annual rate of 2.5 per cent of annual income (Khan, 2012). Other charitable options among Muslims are as follows: *Sadaqah* (i.e. an amount of money or any other thing donated to save oneself from ghosts); *Kaffara* (i.e. offered to needy people in cases where the donor has broken a promise); and *Waqf* (i.e. donation through owing a land to hospital or mosque or to other social service organisation) (Kashif *et al.*, 2015). In Asian countries, the in-group influence is dominant which also influences the charity donation behaviours (Wang, 2014) – an important feature and hallmark of Asian culture. It is empirically demonstrated that in Pakistan, people lack trust in charitable institutions and pay *Zakat* through personal means (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017) which clearly justifies country context selected for this study. Based on the work of Kashif *et al.* (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017), the lack of trust on charity brands where donors donate by personal means threatens the existence and survival of charitable organisations even in the developing world. Thus, current study has a pragmatic value to offer some data-driven marketing strategies which aim to strengthen brand equity (via brand credibility) of charity brands.

A review of relevant theories and concepts surrounding customer-based brand equity (CBBE) will be discussed in terms of the development of our research hypothesis. This will be followed by research methods section where data collection procedures are presented. Finally, the results, discussion, managerial implications and future research direction sections will be presented.

Literature review

Service brand equity

The customer–brand relationships are important for firms to enhance their brand equity which can either be high or low (Rego *et al.*, 2009). A high brand equity results in higher profits; positive word-of-mouth reviews; higher acceptance of firm's potential products and services; maximisation of stakeholder equity; and reduction in the various types of risks associated with buying and consumption of products (Bharadwaj *et al.*, 2011). However, on the other side, weaker consumer–brand relationships result into trust deficit – a dominating reason that brands are rejected (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014) in an era where consumers have choices. There are various models employed by marketing and brand managers to measure brand equity. For instance, the Aaker's (1991) and Keller's (1993) models are two most pertinent and extensively employed frameworks to measure brand equity. In addition to these models, the investigation of brand equity measurement has been enriched by emphasising on employee-based brand equity (King and Grace, 2010) and CEO-based brand equity (Bendisch *et al.*, 2013) frameworks. The central idea in these models is to emphasise one key aspect of the brand, i.e. employees (King and Grace, 2010) as well as the CEOs (Bendisch *et al.*, 2013) to enhance brand equity of the firm in order to achieve marketing outcomes.

In an era where value is said to be is co-created, merely a managerialist stance is insufficient to understand and deliver brand value. In a service environment, active participation of two parties – the customers and frontline employees (during service encounters) – is required to create and deliver value (Jaakkola and Alexander, 2014). The customer disengagement is a critical issue while marketing of services as an active engagement is lacking but ensures marketing success (Naumann *et al.*, 2017). In case employees or the customers are disengaged and are not playing by their script, service is co-destructed – a real threat where firms can easily lose customers for life (Echeverri and Skålén, 2011). This is why an EBBE model was established which expanded from a connectionist perspective (i.e. behavioural responses to different marketing stimuli by an audience external to the firm) to a more culture-based, internal perspective of the firm (King and Grace, 2010). The model is based on several dimensions such as: openness, role clarity, brand commitment, information generation and knowledge dissemination. The scale has not been empirically tested thus lacks external validity. Another group of researchers (Bendisch *et al.*, 2013) took a more holistic view of brand equity measurement and presented another radical model, i.e. CEO-based brand equity. The previously established models incorporated customer, managerial and employee-based views. However, none of the models framed personal branding from a strategist – the corporate-level perspective to establish the brand equity construct. The CEO-based brand equity model consisted of identity, reputation, positioning and equity based on brand creator – the leader. Above all, out of all the matrices available to measure and safeguard brand performance, CBBE has been extensively employed (Christodoulides and De Chernatony, 2010), which is the core reason we selected Aaker's (1991) model to stretch its theoretical scope.

Marketers are under scrutiny by macro and micro environmental factors. Within an organisation, marketing adds to the cost of making products which has motivated brand managers to find ways to maximise return on investments by enhancing brand equity (Mizik and Jacobson, 2008) – acknowledged as an intangible asset to strengthen relationships between organisation and its stakeholders (Christodoulides and De Chernatony, 2010). The trustworthiness and credibility of organisations in the customers' minds act as cues to create brand knowledge among stakeholders (Boenigk and Becker, 2016). Furthermore, brand equity drives brand preference and ultimately purchase intentions (Cobb-Walgren *et al.*, 1995) by increasing the consumers' willingness to pay a premium price (Aaker, 1991). This may be true for profit-centric commercial organisations; however, the non-profit and voluntary services sector has its own realities in terms of management of funds and classification of customers to motivate them to donate for several charities (Kuhn *et al.*, 2008). For instance, a positive brand image in the donors' mind is a source of identity and brings them closer to the brand while making donation decisions (Kashif *et al.*, 2015). The act of donating to a non-profit charitable organisation is more of a social issue than economical in its nature and proper identification and communication of benefits of donation can enable the charity organisations to build successful and trustworthy relationships with their stakeholders (Venable *et al.*, 2005; Lee and Bourne, 2017). In order to attract potential donors and volunteers, charity marketers should manage their marketing efforts in a way to convey the antecedents of brand equity by creating positive images and personalities through greater awareness and familiarity (Stuart, 2016).

There are two highly regarded models of brand equity (Aaker, 1991; Keller, 1993) that are extensively employed by marketing researchers to measure brand equity. The brand, its awareness, association, perceived quality and brand assets are the key components of Aaker's brand equity model. Whereas, Keller's model is comprised of brand equity based on consumers' ability to recall, associate and prefer a brand over others in a competitive landscape. The strength of Aaker's model lies in presenting a managerialist perspective while Keller's model is regarded as an efficient tool to frame consumers' perceptions about a brand and its customers' perceived value. The dominant stream of research in consumer-based brand equity is grounded in cognitive psychology. Aaker (1991) identified brand awareness, associations, loyalty and perceived quality as composites of brand equity. On the other side, Keller (1993) took a more customer-centric approach and defined brand equity as "the differential effect of brand knowledge on consumer response to the marketing of the brand" (p. 2). Both these scholars highlighted the importance of consumer memory in recognising the brand which can ultimately contribute to firm's revenue stream.

Some of the key brand equity measurement models are presented as Table I.

Brand equity and charity sector

Given the identity-based challenges facing charity marketers, there is a dire need felt among marketing researchers to present frameworks which help charity marketers to re-gain recognition through an act of re-branding charity brands (Lee and Bourne, 2017). In this regard, a number of studies are conducted by researchers. Through the study of Faircloth (2005), a conceptual model of resource provider (i.e. volunteers and donors) based on non-profit brand equity was presented. The researcher used multidimensional influences of brand personality (brand respect and brand differentiation); brand image (brand character and brand scale) and brand awareness (brand familiarity) as antecedents of brand equity. The empirical testing of the model yielded mixed results where only brand personality and brand scale, as a sub-dimension under brand image, were found to influence resource

Author(s) and year(s)	Theoretical paradigm	Contribution
Aaker's (1991) model	Cognitive psychology	Brand awareness, association, perceived, quality, brand loyalty
Keller's (1993) model	Network memory model, theory of semantic processor, attitude theory	Brand knowledge – awareness and associations
Erdem and Swait's (1998) model	Signalling theory	Brand credibility, brand clarity, consistency, perceived quality, perceived risk, information costs saved and expected utility
King and Grace's (2010) employee-based brand equity	Leader-member exchange theory, relationship-mediated theory of internal marketing, commitment – trust theory	Openness, the "*H*" factor, knowledge dissemination, information generation, role clarity and brand commitment
Bendisch *et al.*'s (2013) CEO-based brand equity	Social identity theory, stakeholder theory	Creator perspective – identity (human, managerial and CEO); stakeholder perspective – reputation (human, managerial and CEO)

Table I.
Key brand equity measurement models

providers' internal altruistic tendency to volunteer (Faircloth, 2005). The conventional belief of brand familiarity yielding positive brand equity was rejected through this study which highlights that negative perception towards the organisation might be manifesting this donor behaviour. This also calls for establishing stronger corporate brands in the charity sector to further strengthen donor trust – avoiding brand rejection in the charity sector (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014).

The issue of brand rejection is sensitive in nature as it is noticeable that donors, once they lack trust in the charities, opt for substitutes and donate by personal means (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017) which is a threat to the growth of charity brands. The researchers Becker-Olsen and Hill (2006) used measures from the CBBE Scale developed by Keller (2001), based on the four components, namely, brand identity, brand meaning, brand response and brand relationship, to identify the sponsor fit with brand equity. Further to this, extending their study, Hou *et al.* (2009) used Faircloth's model to test the individual giving intention with the mediating role of individual donor's self-concept. These researchers found that the three dimensions of brand equity, i.e. brand personality, brand image and brand awareness of the non-profit organisation, leave highly positive direct effects on an individual's donation intention. This study further validated Faircloth's (2005) findings that communication of charity brand image to donors acts as a significant contributor to motivate donors' support behaviour.

Extending the research further, Juntunen *et al.* (2013) focussed on developing a B2B brand equity model based on the study of Davis *et al.* (2008) to describe the co-creation of non-profit brand equity. These researchers focussed on two constructs, i.e. non-profit brand awareness and non-profit brand image as antecedents of co-created non-profit brand equity. The results further validated the positive effects of brand image and associations to establish brand equity of a non-profit organisation. However, as per the limitation of their study, they missed few unique constructs to examine brand equity of non-profit organisations and suggested doing the same as an important future research direction. In another study, Laidler-Kylander and Simonin (2009) followed a different methodology and used the grounded theory and a system dynamics approach to construct the brand equity model for international non-profits organisations. They proposed a model highlighting the role of four key variables that drive brand equity in non-profit organisations: consistency, focus, trust and partnerships. They suggested to elaborate on these dimensions through few quantitative studies to empirically test the proposed framework. Apart from that, donor trust evolved as an important variable in their study, which further strengthens the rationale to establish brand credibility in the charity sector – resulting into consumer trust and other tangible outcomes.

The researchers Boenigk and Becker (2016) conceptualised a stakeholder-based brand equity framework by emphasising brand awareness, non-profit brand trust and non-profit brand commitment to enhance public's attitude towards organisation. This was aimed at uplifting the strategic position of the brand in the market. They found brand trust to strongly effect donor behaviour, but also acknowledged that their study presents an initial model where future researchers should take this to next level. It is also noteworthy that some of these models framed non-profit events and organisations such as the Ages of Mankind Exhibition in Spain (Camarero *et al.*, 2010), National Museum of Natural Sciences in Taiwan (Liu *et al.*, 2015), Finnish Defence Forces military driving school (Juntunen *et al.*, 2013) and the likes, which is somewhat different from the social and charitable brands – the focus of this research. None of the above mentioned studies adapted Aaker's model of brand equity but used a variety of multidimensional variables to measure its influence on perceived brand equity of charity brands. Another important outcome achieved through critical review of these models is the fact that branding elements of awareness, image, and brand trust are important, yet studied in isolation of the CBBE model where a cohesive framework, the one which presents all these constructs as a unified framework, is missing.

Furthermore, there is plethora of research which highlights the importance of brand equity, its underlying theoretical paradigms and prominent constructs but the brand credibility in the charity sector is scarcely examined and presented. Recently, the credibility of charity organisations is investigated but a more holistic (i.e. organisational perspective) is taken forth to examine the issue of brand equity (Rahayu Hijrah Hati and Idris, 2014; Kim *et al.*, 2017). These researchers further suggested to deepen our understanding of brand credibility of charity brands by conducting few more studies by considering the unique constructs to strengthen donor engagement and loyalty (Curran *et al.*, 2016). The donor confidence on charity organisations is crucial element in establishing brand equity but charity marketers have failed to establish donor trust – a branding dilemma (McDougle, 2014) – which needs our scholarly attention. Hence, it can be argued that brand performance measurements need conceptual grooming that can easily lead to the enhancement of charitable brand performance. Despite the need and importance of brand credibility realised among charity marketers (Spry *et al.*, 2011), the measurement of brand equity lacks the integration of brand credibility which we believe must be vested into brand equity metrics in order to counteract marketing challenges. Inculcating brand credibility into brand equity matrices can guide service marketers to improve brand performance (Hyun Baek and Whitehill King, 2011) – an important contribution of this study to extend charity marketing literature.

Hypothesis and theory development

The research model for this study is based on the conceptualisations of brand equity offered by two classic models of brand management – Aaker (1991) and Keller (1993). The brand equity dimensions are elaborated in the next subsections.

Perceived quality and brand equity

One of the primary facets of the CBBE model is the perceived quality where Aaker (1991) referred to the trust, supremacy and truthfulness of the brand claims as perceived by its targeted consumer. It means that a brand must ensure it is perceived as trustworthy for its communication (i.e. advertising, public relations) to leave a positive impact on customers (Delgado-Ballester and Luis Munuera-Alemán, 2005) – a product of their past experiences with the brand. The importance of perceived quality has been well recognised among charity marketers. High perceived quality offers several benefits to the brand such as: to differentiate it from other competing brands; to charge a higher price; and to leverage existing brand equity to support brand extensions (Keller, 1993). According to Zeithaml (1981), the provision of positive feedback enhances the quality of the service delivered and perceived – an important part of service quality offered by non-profit organisation (Merchant *et al.*, 2010). McGrath (1997) identified this as the service value which is defined as the actions performed by charity organisations to convince donors to render positive feedback, handle complaints and appreciate the brand. The researcher further emphasised that the service value offers the opportunity for charities to increase donors' satisfaction – an indicator of excellent service quality (Ramanath (2016). The researchers Sargeant and Lee (2002) highlighted the fact that receiving feedback from the charities, appreciation of the gift received and rapid responsiveness concerning queries are among the main attitudinal elements of donors leading towards perceived service quality on the charities – to establish stronger consumer–brand ties.

The consumer perceptions of quality are extremely important for non-profit service organisations to ignite a positive donor response towards the marketing efforts of charity brands (Kashif *et al.*, 2015). Apart from the positive donor response, perceived quality directly influences the corporate performance as well (Aaker, 1991) in terms of revenue and goodwill. A high perceived quality positively contributes to enhance and improve brand equity perceptions among donors of charity organisations (Mulyanegara, 2011). However, it must be noted that perceived quality is not a stand-alone component which contributes to enhancement of brand equity (Tong and Hawley, 2009). Rather, the integration of perceived quality with other components of CBBE is recommended to maximise charity brand equity. Based on the existing relationship between perceived quality and brand equity, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H1. The donor perceived quality positively contributes to brand equity of charity brands.

Brand awareness

Brand awareness is attributed to strong brand recognition and recall (Keller, 1993). In an era where consumers have choices (as they can donate through different means) (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017), the importance of brand awareness (i.e. the ability of a potential donor to identify and associate a brand with a specific product category) (Aaker, 1991) cannot be neglected for charity brands. The researchers (Boenigk and Becker, 2016; Faircloth, 2005; Juntunen *et al.*, 2013) have used brand awareness as a substantial dimension in building non-profit brand equity. They highlighted that donors, once they are positively associated with charity brands, are able to recognise themselves with the organisation and also spread positive word-of-mouth to others. A high brand awareness among donors results in a favourable response to marketing efforts and contributes to the growth of charity organisations (Baghi *et al.*, 2009). There are several tools employed by brands to communicate brand-related information to key stakeholders, especially to donors. In this regard, the role of television as a medium to generate brand recognition and recall has been enumerated by advertising researchers (Kashif *et al.*, 2014) which may be useful for charity brands – depending upon the target market(s). Furthermore, among the challenges faced by brands, brand recognition is envisioned as a key priority for organisations (Laran and Wilcox, 2011), which is also true for charity brand marketers. Thus the following hypothesis is proposed:

H2. The donor perceived brand awareness positively contributes to brand equity of charity brands.

Brand association

The consumer memory is important for brands. On the one hand, it helps brands to generate recall (Boenigk and Becker, 2016) while, on the other hand, there are set of cues in the memory – to form a set of favourable, strong and unique associations about a brand – collectively known as brand associations (Keller, 1993). The strength of brand associations positively contributes to development of a brand image that enhances brand equity via stronger customer–brand relationships to safeguard a brand from its competition (Keller, 2016). One of the challenges charity sector brands face is the possibility of a weak brand image which must be encountered through efficient brand building strategies (Juntunen *et al.*, 2013).

It has already been noted that a weaker consumer–brand relationship can easily lead to brand rejection (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014), which requires careful attention from the charity brand marketers. This is so true even in the developing world where donors do not frequently donate through charities and prefer donations by personal means (Kashif *et al.*, 2015). More importantly, it is not only a matter of poor perceived quality of charity brands; rather, the donor–brand relationships are weak (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017), which is a product of low brand awareness and associations. Further to this, these researchers (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017) also explored that donors are unable to derive meaning through brand consumption (i.e. by donating to charity organisations in our case) – clearly an issue of weaker brand associations. This is also attributed to a weaker position of charity brands (i.e. once compared to donation through personal means) – a matter of weak emotional bonding and trust. Furthermore, in a collectivist culture where people know each other, donating through personal means is more satisfying (Kashif and De Run, 2015). These researchers recommended strengthening the donor–brand relationships in developing world to strengthen consumer–brand relationships. Keeping these issues in mind, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H3. The donor perceived brand association positively contributes to brand equity of charity brands.

Brand loyalty

Brand loyalty is yet another important component of the CBBE model and refers to the ability of a consumer to purchase a brand on a consistent basis over a period of time (Aaker, 1991). In addition to consistently buying a brand, strong brand loyalty results in consumers' intention to spread positive word-of-mouth reviews to potential users (Keller, 1993). This entails that brand loyalty is a source of spreading brand-related information to other customers. This has been highlighted as an important function of brands where brand-related information is passed on from one consumer to the other – leading to establishment of stronger brand communities (Hassay and Peloza, 2009).

The brand communities, mainly a group of individuals with high brand congruence (i.e. the ability of consumers to perceive brand value as in-sync with their personal values), are a product of brand loyalty which is regarded as a tool to safeguard a brand from the realm of stronger competition. For non-profit brands, the brand loyalty is weak and is recognised as a key area of improvement (Juntunen *et al.*, 2013). The researchers also believe that strong brand loyalty generates profitable returns for the firm which is pivotal for growth and survival of organisations. The brand switching is a common phenomenon observed among donors of charity brands which can be minimised to a certain extent by strengthening loyalty (Bennett, 2009). The individuals, since they do not feel a strong emotional relationship with the brand (mainly due to weak donor–brand relationships) (Lee and Bourne, 2017), are likely to reject it and may switch to other service providers (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014). In other extreme situations, the donors may never come back to donate to charity brands as they will find other substitutes to donate (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017) – a threat to growth and survival of charity brands.

This highlights brand loyalty to be an important component contributing to brand equity for charity organisations. Thus, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H4. The donor perceived brand loyalty positively contributes to brand equity of charity brands.

Moderation of brand credibility

In the realm of strong competition, brands use cues as signals to communicate brand-related information to trigger positive outcomes of purchase and loyalty (Erdem and Swait, 1998, Alias and Rasdi, 2015). According to brand management researchers (Erdem and Swait, 1998), brand credibility refers to consumers' perceptions of the ability and willingness of a brand to deliver on the brand promise over a period of time. Brand credibility is different when compared with other constructs used to measure brand equity in a sense that it takes an insider view of a service firm. This is regarded as the firm's ability to deliver on the brand promises, as perceived by its customers (Hyun Baek and Whitehill King, 2011). This indicates that brand credibility is a combined effect of all the prior marketing actions (Erdem *et al.*, 2002) and to the extent these actions are consistent (Baek *et al.*, 2010).

The brand credibility comprises of two components, i.e. trustworthiness and expertise (Erdem and Swait, 1998; Erdem and Swait, 2004). The trustworthiness refers to perceived willingness of a firm to deliver on the brand promise while expertise refers to the perceived ability of firms to actually deliver value (Bougoure *et al.*, 2016). Since its inception, the brand credibility has been regarded as a unidimensional construct – combining the collective impact of trustworthiness and expertise to link it to other marketing outcomes (Erdem and Swait, 1998; Bougoure *et al.*, 2016; Shams *et al.*, 2017). These researchers further suggested employing this construct as a unidimensional to study its combined effects on marketing outcomes.

According to Erdem and Swait (2004), the information acquisition costs and perceived risks are to be incurred by consumers which delays consumers' decision making – driving weaker consumer confidence (Hyun Baek and Whitehill King, 2011) – which can be reduced by using brand cues. Thus, brand credibility can provide unbeatable benefits to customers through assurance of quality and it can benefit the companies also through higher message acceptance and repeat customers (Baek *et al.*, 2010). Furthermore, brand credibility is an essential tool to develop word-of-mouth for a brand and can minimise brand switching intentions through establishing stronger customer–brand relationships (Sweeney and Swait, 2008). In service settings, brand credibility can offer several advantages to the firm which include; high relationship equity, decreased risk perceptions and a positive response to marketing activities (Long and Chiagouris, 2006). When consumer risks (associated with buying and consumption of services) are properly managed through brand credibility, it leads to stronger ties between customers and brands (Leischnig *et al.*, 2012).

The initial brand credibility model (Erdem and Swait, 1998) highlighted the role of trustworthiness and expertise of a brand, which are signals to the customers and can positively contribute to the enhancement of brand equity. This assumption we believe is true and more important in case of service organisations where employee and customers interact during service encounters and value is co-created (Brodie, 2009). The product categories which are difficult to evaluate, customers perceive high risk associated with purchase and consumption of such products (Jones and Shandiz, 2015). In cases where risk perception is not properly managed, it can drive brand rejection (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014). This entails that consumer confidence in trustworthiness and expertise of the firm to meet brand promises are few critical success factors for a service firm. In an era of high competition, non-profit and charity brands are facing the challenge of the lack of credibility (Hyun Baek and Whitehill King, 2011), which, if not encountered strategically by charity organisations, will increase charity brand rejection (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014). Charity brands should pledge assurances that the provider is worthy of trust in order to reduce the uncertainties (Weisbrod, 2009) associated with purchase and consumption of service brands. This further validates the role played by brand credibility to develop trustworthy relationships – the core reason leading to brand rejection (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014).

The brand credibility construct is empirically tested in isolation of the CBBE framework (Christodoulides and De Chernatony, 2010; Bougoure *et al.*, 2016), which entails that it has not yet been integrated into a CBBE framework as a moderating variable. Few recent attempts signify the importance of credibility as a construct, but it has been employed with a different theoretical mind-set than our study. For instance, corporate credibility is examined to investigate its impact on positive marketing outcomes (Kim *et al.*, 2017). Few others linked it to innovation and purchase intentions (Shams *et al.*, 2017), and also an effort is made to examine its relationships with brand equity (Spry *et al.*, 2011), but still the context of charity brands and a collectivist Muslim country is missing. This is important in an era where charity brands are suggested to employ innovative means to reposition their brands (Lee and Bourne, 2017), and also there are threats from substitutes where people prefer to donate by personal means (Kashif and De Run, 2015) rather than donating through charities. In an era where people lack trust and credibility on charity brands (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017), the study has its value.

Keeping in view the challenges facing charity marketers and suggestions offered to enrich brand equity measurement models, we propose a moderating effect of brand credibility. This is because there is empirical evidence to demonstrate that people are religious (Kashif, Zarkada and Thurasamy, 2017) and also pay charity on a regular basis (Kashif *et al.*, 2015), but they only donate to means where they trust and perceive as credible (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017). This way, we believe the relationship between brands and the customers can be further strengthened where customer perceive brands to be more credible. Thus, the following hypotheses have been proposed:

H5. The relationship between perceived quality and brand equity is strengthened when moderated by high brand credibility.

H6. The relationship between brand awareness and brand equity is strengthened when moderated by high brand credibility.

H7. The relationship between brand association and brand equity is strengthened when moderated by high brand credibility.

H8. The relationship between brand loyalty and brand equity is strengthened when moderated by high brand credibility (Figure 1).

Research methods

Sampling and data collection

In accordance with a positivist worldview, this study aims to objectively employ and test the proposed relationships in an extended CBBE framework. For this purpose, a cross-sectional, survey-based design is adopted. The choice of cross-sectional research design is based on the notion that it saves time and is objective in nature as postulated by researchers in previously conducted studies of CBBE (Tong and Hawley, 2009). The sample population for this study comprised of all people who have donated once in the last two months to a charity organisation. This was to ensure that data are collected truly from actual donors of charity organisations. We were interested specifically in seeking the opinion of those respondents who donated to charities recently. There is

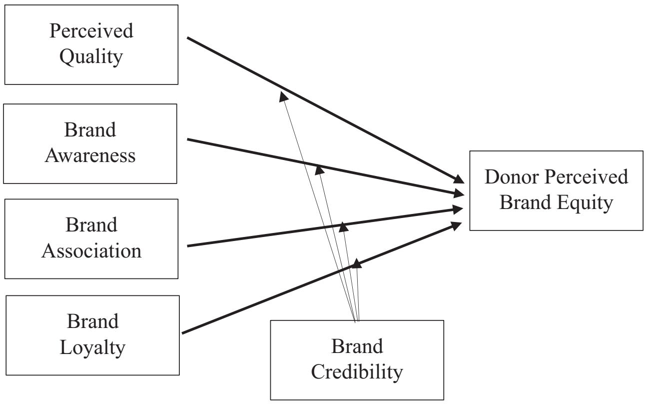

Figure 1.
The conceptual model

empirical demonstration of the fact that in countries such as Pakistan, people do not usually donate through charities rather they use personal means to pay the amount of *Zakat* to poor and needy people (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017).

Interestingly, it is noted that in countries such as Pakistan people donate for different motives. These motives include, in addition to Zakat donation, the motives such as *Sadaqah, Kaffara* and *Waqf* (Kashif *et al.*, 2015). Furthermore, these researchers identified that people from all walks of life donate, disregarding their socio-economic class or their socio-demographic status. The research team approached respondents at various locations in the city of Lahore, including universities and shopping malls. The respondents were briefed about research objectives in order to encourage them to voluntarily partake in this survey. Once the respondents, who were randomly approached, agreed to participate in this research, the data collection team handed over them the questionnaires with a request to consider charities in general while filling in their responses against the questionnaire items. In total, 500 questionnaires were distributed where 448 respondents in total agreed and filled in the questionnaires – all in a usable form with a response rate of 89 per cent.

Measurements

We adopted already published scales to measure constructs of this study. The dimensions of perceived quality, brand awareness, brand association and brand loyalty were adopted from the study of Tong and Hawley (2009). The measures of perceived quality were adapted to embrace the donors' quality perceptions about charity brands as suggested by researchers, i.e. Merchant *et al.* (2010). These scales have excellent statistical validity as reported by Tong and Hawley (2009). The scale comprised of three items of Perceived quality ($\alpha = 0.73$), three items for brand awareness ($\alpha = 0.68$), four items to measure brand association ($\alpha = 0.70$), five items of brand loyalty ($\alpha = 0.80$) and three items for brand equity ($\alpha = 0.60$) with excellent α scores. The brand credibility, a six-item scale, was also adopted from the study of Hyun Baek and Whitehill King (2011). The scale for this construct was used as unidiensional for this study with excellent reliability ($\alpha = 0.95$). There were small modifications made. For instance, in the previous studies, the researchers used phrases about products which were rephrased as "the charity brand I donate for". These small changes were necessary and do not require any statistical remedy. In a similar context, the researchers made changes to original items – modified to best suit these items to the context without any statistical remedies reported (Kashif *et al.*, 2015). Theoretically, this way, the sense of items remained the same which is yet another reason we did not opt for any statistical remedy for this small modification made to these scales. In this regard, a five-point Likert scale was employed (5 = strongly agree, 4 = agree, 3 = neutral, 2 = disagree and 1 = strongly disagree).

Social desirability and common method bias

During the conduct of survey research, it is noticed that the respondents have the tendency to discuss survey items among each other to seek social approval of their choices which can bias survey responses. On the other side, respondent's motivation to actively fill-in the questionnaire, to a large extent, is dependent upon an appropriate length of questionnaire. These two issues cause social desirability and common method biases, respectively. Hence, in order to minimise the effect of these biases, research team ensured that respondents are sitting at a fair distance from each other and are not discussing the survey items among each other to ensure avoidance of social desirability bias – a remedy noted in the previously held survey (Kashif and De Run, 2015) – proved as a useful tactic to avoid survey bias. Furthermore, the length of questionnaire was restricted to minimum items – necessary to measure the constructs used in this study. Notably, the constructs with high reliability scores were adopted from studies published in highly respectable outlets. Hence, the quality of measurement is not compromised while managing survey biases. These techniques are highly recommended by quantitative researchers to establish credibility of research designs (Conway and Lance, 2010).

Results

There were 448 responses in total and are detailed as Table II. The major strength of the sample is equal proportion of male and female respondents. The data set is skewed towards younger respondents which is justified as a large proportion of the Pakistani population (almost 70 per cent) which is below the age of 24 years. The sample is representative of the Pakistani population in terms of age.

Data analysis

We used the partial least squares structural equation modelling technique using Smart PLS 2.0, a second-generation analysis software, to conduct data analysis for this study. This is suggested to use in situations where complex models with latent variables are to be analysed (Ringle *et al.*, 2005). In this regard, the research team followed a two-stage analytical procedure as recommended by Anderson and Gerbing (1988). At an initial stage,

Demographics	Frequency	Percentage
Age		
18–27	405	90.4
28–36	34	7.6
37–49	9	2.0
50 and above	0	0.0
Gender		
Male	225	50.2
Female	223	49.8
	448	100.0
Marital status		
Single	410	91.5
Married	29	6.5
Others	9	2.0

Table II. Sample respondents

the measurement model was assessed in order to validate the instruments. This led us to test of the structural model to assess the hypothetical relationships proposed in this study.

The quantitative researchers strongly recommend to ensure reliability and validity of data which helps to establish credibility of research designs (Hair *et al.*, 2011, 2014). Hence, for this purpose, convergent validity (CV) and discriminant validity (DV) were envisioned. The researchers also recommend the establishment of a measurement model before a structural model is presented. The results of Table III reveal excellent validity scores. To finalise the measurement model, we first assessed the loadings for each item used for the outer model. The suggestions such as loadings should exceed a value of 0.7 – a rule of thumb (Hair *et al.*, 2011). All the loadings exceeded the recommended value of 0.7 except for item number 3 under brand association dimension, and were numerated as 0.698 (Table III). It is strongly suggested if the composite reliability (CR) is more than 0.7 and the AVE exceeds 0.5, then the item can still be retained (Hair *et al.*, 2014). Keeping this in mind, we retained this item.

To complement the CV, we tested the DV using the established criterion (Fornell and Larcker, 1981). An observation of Table IV shows that the CR values are all above 0.7 and the AVE is also exceeding the value of 0.5. Thus, we are certain that CV has been achieved. Furthermore, from Table IV, we can observe that the square roots of AVE, which are shown

Variable	Factor loadings	AVE	CR
Perceived quality			
PQ1	0.711	0.604	0.821
PQ2	0.709		
PQ3	0.793		
Brand awareness			
B4	0.712	0.576	0.802
B5	0.879		
B6	0.802		
Brand association			
BA7	0.792		
BA8	0.711		
BA9	0.698	0.550	0.785
BA10	0.773		
Brand loyalty			
BL11	0.710	0.575	0.802
BL12	0.811		
BL13	0.769		
BL14	0.721		
BL15	0.822		
Brand equity			
BE16	0.844		
BE17	0.843	0.582	0.807
BE18	0.818		
Brand credibility			
BC19	0.771	0.782	0.878
BC20	0.733		
BC21	0.773		
BC22	0.810		
BC23	0.721		
BC24	0.709		

Table III. Standardized confirmatory factor loadings on the diagonals, are all higher than their respective row and column values. It indicates that the measurements are discriminant. Thus, based on this assessment, we can conclude that our study has sufficient validity and reliability.

Structural model

The structural model was tested by running a bootstrapping procedure with a re-sampling of 1,000. The R^2 for the main effect model without the interaction was 0.513, and when the interaction terms were added, the R^2 increased to 0.540 – resulting in an R^2 change of 0.027. The effect size of this change f^2 was 0.0587, which can be considered small effect.

Brand awareness ($\beta = 0.91$, $p < 0.05$), brand association ($\beta = 0.074$, $p < 0.05$) and brand loyalty ($\beta = 0.324$, $p < 0.01$) were positively related to brand equity whereas perceived quality was not found as significant. Of the four predictors, the most important predictor of brand equity was brand loyalty, followed by brand awareness, and, to a much lower extent, brand association. Thus, *H2*–*H4* were supported, while *H1* was not supported. These are observations from Table V.

For the moderating effect analysis, out of the four interaction terms, only two terms were found significant. For instance, we found support for brand credibility × perceived quality ($\beta = 0.060$, $p < 0.1$) and brand credibility × brand loyalty ($\beta = 0.86$, $p < 0.05$). Thus, *H5* and *H8* were supported, whilst *H6* and *H7* were not supported. To see the effect more clearly, we plotted the interaction effect in Figures 2 and 3.

Figure 2 shows the relationship between brand loyalty and brand equity which is positive for both the levels of brand credibility – much stronger when the perceived brand credibility is higher. This indicates that brand credibility enhances the strength of the loyalty–equity relationship in a CBBE model. This entails that loyalty of donors will bring positive brand equity in cases where donors perceive charity brand to be highly credible.

As for the product–quality–brand equity relationship (as per Figure 3), it is noted when brand credibility is high, the relationship between product quality and brand equity remains

Construct	Mean	SD	AVE	CR	BAssoc	BAware	BC	BE	BL	PQ
Brand association	3.458	0.816	0.550	0.785	*0.741*					
Brand awareness	3.386	0.843	0.576	0.802	0.479	*0.759*				
Brand credibility	3.475	0.673	0.782	0.878	0.561	0.542	*0.884*			
Brand equity	3.456	0.798	0.582	0.807	0.495	0.491	0.643	*0.763*		
Brand loyalty	3.465	0.794	0.575	0.802	0.560	0.511	0.617	0.640	*0.758*	
Perceived quality	3.482	0.786	0.604	0.821	0.568	0.520	0.604	0.465	0.550	*0.777*

Notes: AVE, average variance extracted; CR, composite reliability. Values in italics are the square root of the AVE while the off-diagonals are the correlation

Table IV. Descriptive, AVE, CR and discriminant validity

Hypothesis	Relationship	β	SE	*t*-value	Decision
H1	Perceived quality → brand equity	−0.027	0.031	0.891	Not supported
H2	Brand awareness → brand equity	0.091	0.042	2.186**	Supported
H3	Brand association → brand equity	0.074	0.043	1.717**	Supported
H4	Brand loyalty → brand equity	0.324	0.050	6.517**	Supported
H5	Brand credibility × perceived quality → brand equity	0.060	0.041	1.445*	Supported
H6	Brand credibility × brand awareness → brand equity	−0.004	0.026	0.172	Not supported
H7	Brand credibility × brand association → brand equity	0.006	0.030	0.184	Not supported
H8	Brand credibility × brand loyalty → brand equity	0.086	0.044	1.983**	Supported

Notes: $*p > 0.05$; $**p > 0.01$

Table V. Hypothesis testing

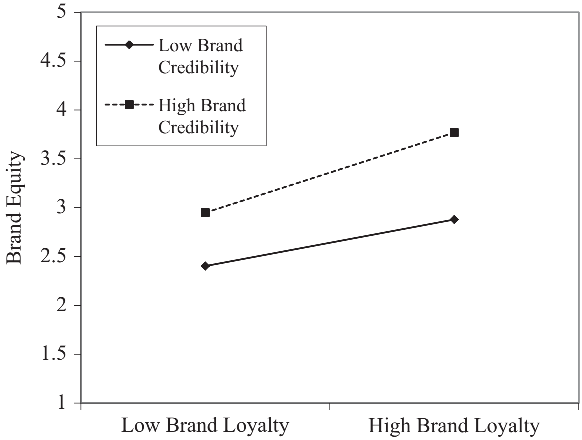

Figure 2.
Brand equity and loyalty relationship

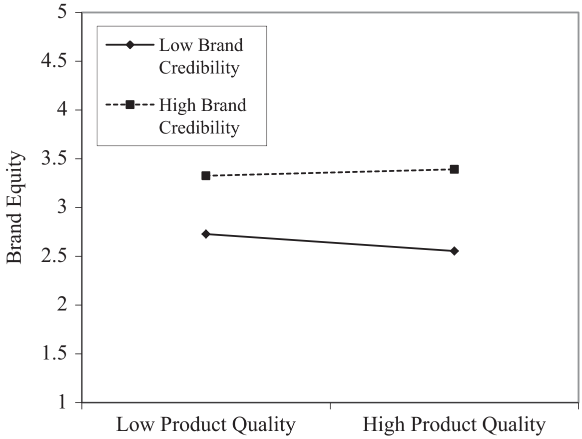

Figure 3.
Brand equity and product quality relationship

the same. Hence, it does not matter if product quality is high or low. For those with low brand credibility, the relationship becomes negative when perception of product quality increases. This has clear implications for charity brand marketers where they need to enhance consumer confidence through high brand credibility efforts.

Discussion

There is excellent amount of research already published where brand credibility is used to examine branding issues (Bougoure *et al.*, 2016; Shams *et al.*, 2017; Hyun Baek and Whitehill King, 2011). Despite the extant literature on brand credibility, the studies where this construct is positioned as a moderating variable are limited – a clear gap which we aim to bridge. In an effort to advance theory, management scholars have suggested to use a moderation approach to enhance the efficiency of existing models and theories (Haynes *et al.*, 2014). This is where we contribute to the existing branding literature by positioning brand credibility as a moderating variable to investigate donor–brand relationships under a CBBE model. More specifically, at a pragmatic level, the proposed model is empirically tested among regular donors and is better suited to enhance brand equity of charity brands in a dominantly Muslim country, Pakistan. Keeping in view the weak donor–brand relationships, the brand management scholars have recently advocated the idea to rebrand charity organisations (Lee and Bourne, 2017) so that donors can derive meaning by consuming the charity brands. The issue of brand credibility is important in an era where consumers have choices and there are weaker donor–brand relationships in terms of credibility of charity brands (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017). This is a key reason the donors will reject brands (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014), which qualifies brand credibility as an important feature of modern-day charity brand programmes.

The results demonstrate that brand awareness ($\beta = 0.91, p < 0.05$), brand association ($\beta = 0.074, p < 0.05$) and brand loyalty ($\beta = 0.324, p < 0.01$) positively relate to brand equity of charity brands. However, perceived quality ($\beta = -0.027, p > 0.05$) was not positively related to brand equity. The results further strengthen the traditionally established models of brand equity (Aaker, 1991; Keller, 1993) where the importance of brand awareness, association and loyalty has been enumerated. There is tough competition among charity brands and also the availability of substitute means of donation (i.e. donation to individuals by personal means) (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017) which requires stronger consumer–brand ties – awareness and associations are regarded as keys to establish long-lasting relationships. The brand recall is a starting point to establish stronger brands (Boenigk and Becker, 2016) which, if not achieved, can lead to brand rejection (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014). The results also highlight a positive and significant effect of brand loyalty on brand equity which has few contextual reasons. The in-group influence is important in charity programmes offered by firms in an Asian context (Wang, 2014), which has the potential to shift consumer loyalties in a way that individuals influence each other to shape their opinions. This in-group effect binds people together to develop brand communities – to strengthen brand equity (Hassay and Peloza, 2009). This way, stronger patterns of the loyalty–equity relationship are understandable in an Asian context.

Unexpectedly, the direct relationship between perceived quality and brand equity of charity brands is not validated. This confirms the findings of a study based on the evidence from manufacturing sector of China (Tong and Hawley, 2009) where results were not statistically validated to explain the relationship between perceived quality and equity. This can be attributed to the study of Camarero *et al.* (2010), where they highlighted perceived quality as one of the few variables to strengthen brand equity, yet not the only variable. Hence, our findings support the results of their study from a charity branding perspective. There are weaker donor–brand relationships noted in the charity sector (Kashif and De Run, 2015), which can be improved by strengthening consumer trust in charity brands (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014) – making trust and credibility as important features of service brands (Hyun Baek and Whitehill King, 2011) to enhance brand equity instead of perceived high quality of charity brands. Another perspective is that core motive behind charity donation (mostly *Zakat* as a charity is donated which is obligatory on part of Muslims) among Muslims is to seek Allah's forgiveness. In this way, *Zakat* donation is regarded as a source of spiritual comfort (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017). Since this act of donation is only meant for Allah's forgiveness, the gift giving, features of service in terms of facilities offered, courteous staff and comfort are less important,which are hallmarks of perceived service quality, advocated by researchers to increase donors' satisfaction (Ramanath (2016). In this way, the lack of statistical support for this relationship is understandable. The brand awareness and brand association to equity path is not moderated by brand credibility. The awareness and associations are basic tenants of a brand strategy (McDougle, 2014) – the absence of these cannot drive consumer confidence – an imperative to establish positive equity for the brands. Hence, it can be safely assumed that in cases where brands lack awareness and association, the brand credibility cannot be established. Thus, it is inferred that the most important predictor of brand equity is brand loyalty, followed by brand awareness, and then brand association.

Brand credibility was integrated as an additional construct to strengthen the relationships proposed under the traditional CBBE model. The four iterations were initially established to measure moderating effects of brand credibility on consumer perceived brand equity. Among the four relationships proposed, only two relationships were found significant, i.e. brand credibility × perceived quality ($\beta = 0.060$, $p < 0.1$) and brand credibility × brand loyalty ($\beta = 0.86$, $p < 0.05$). These results are in line with the results of studies conducted (Hyun Baek and Whitehill King, 2011). This also postulates a strong role played by brand credibility to counter branding challenges such as low brand loyalty and brand rejection of charity organisations (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014). This highlights the importance of brand credibility to enhance quality perceptions about the brand. Furthermore, in a context where charity brands are facing competition from category (product based) as well as non-category players (i.e. substitutes such as donation through personal means) (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017), brand credibility is a source to strengthen charity brand loyalty. The moderation of brand credibility with brand loyalty is also understood contextually as charity brands operating in Pakistan are regarded as less credible where individuals use personal means to donate (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017) – a credibility crisis to hinder charity brand loyalty.

Managerial implications

The charity brands need to establish a strong brand image in the minds of donors and other stakeholders. In this context, it is notable that charity brands, so far, have failed to instil a positive image in donors' mind (Juntunen *et al.*, 2013) – a major threat to foster growth and survival of charity brands. The positive brand image and reputation can be increased by participating in various programmes such as child education in a country (i.e. Pakistan) where millions of children do not attend school. This will add to brand reputation (Meijer, 2009) which can also be achieved by arranging various awareness programmes and trainings to counter epidemics such as Polio, HIV and Hepatitis in particular. A core benefit of this tactic is that it is not glamourous (i.e. such as CSR initiatives by brands offering other than charity products) rather congruent with the charity brand image (e.g. a charity brand is supposed to help the poor and needy). This way, it is expected to bring positive outcomes for charity brands.

It is notable that charity brands lack donors' emotional attachment with brands to result in brand rejection (Faulkner *et al.*, 2014). Thus, there is a need to develop stronger ties through emotional bonding between a charity brand and its donors – leading to spread of positive WOM to safeguard the brand from its competition (Bennett, 2009). This can lead to credible brand signalling in order to address the trust deficit on charities among donors. The charity brands can ignite loyalty by offering loyalty programmes to donors. We are suggesting the establishment of donor programmes to generate loyalty because people donate every year. For example, Muslims are abided by Islamic Shari'ah to pay the suggested amount of *Zakat* every year to poor and needy people. These people can be attracted every year to donate money through charities. The collection of donation amount from conveniently located centres and discounted service charges can help to attract potential donors to charity organisations. Initiatives such as loyalty or even membership programmes can also be useful to trigger donors' commitment (Camarero *et al.*, 2010).

Moreover, brand credibility can be ensured by demonstrating the experience of existing customers who donated in recent past, and their money was safely transferred to poor and needy people. It will add to the development of trust between donors and charity brands where trust is acknowledged as a core component to establish brand credibility (Laidler-Kylander and Simonin, 2009; McDougle, 2014). Furthermore, charity brands can focus on communicating their efficiency by sharing their annual accounts to the donors. The arrangement of special events such as open house might result in enhancement of trust and credibility. There is also a need to establish the expertise of a charity brand to enable brand teams to meet the brand promise. The proposition is based on the fact that donors are doubtful about the brand's ability to deliver on promises, i.e. charities lack resources to meet brand promise (McDougle, 2014). Charity brands can establish the believability component by designing brand promotion campaigns which focus on portraying the skills, knowledge and ability of employees to be able to meet brand promise. It is empirically demonstrated that charity brands in countries such as Pakistan are facing troubles from non-category competitors, i.e. the donors donate by personal means (Kashif, Faisal Jamal and Abdul Rehman, 2017). This can be encountered by promoting EBBE (King and Grace, 2010) – portraying and demonstrating positive stories of excellent performance of employees to establish trust.

Finally, while establishing a direct relationship between brand awareness and brand equity, charity brands need to focus on establishing brand recognition and recall. In this regard, consumer-led brand promotions by emphasising organisational credibility can contribute to shape positive attitude concerning charity brands (Rahayu Hijrah Hati and Idris, 2014). Apart from the brand investments through advertising, the charity brands should focus on being more socially responsible in their actions to demonstrate that the firm is committed to the communicated brand image which can strengthen brand credibility perceptions (Erdem and Swait, 1998).

Limitations and future research directions

The present study has few limitations which also provide avenues for future research. The extended model although provided some novel insights to enrich our understanding of branding the charity organisations, the data are collected only from donors. The employment of such an approach is recommended in situations where a pragmatist insight is needed (Kashif and De Run, 2015) as in the case of this study. However, future research is recommended to incorporate more service brands from other sectors which have the potential to bring much more theoretical richness to the proposed framework. In this regard, all the service products which are classified under high in credence quality can be investigated by employing this framework based on brand credibility. The core reason is that customers' perceived risks are high while evaluating all those services which are difficult to evaluate and lie under the category of high in credence attribute (Jones and Shandiz, 2015).

Second, the measures used in this study were developed in western contexts which are far different from the Pakistani context on account of culture. Future studies are recommended to employ measurement (i.e. configural and metric) invariance to strengthen the methodology and statistical results.

Third, the brand credibility is regarded and treated as a unidimensional construct which is a limitation of this study. The construct is treated as unidimensional by considering the fact that researchers in previously held studies also used it as a unidimensional construct (Erdem and Swait, 1998; Bougoure *et al.*, 2016; Shams *et al.*, 2017). This also served the purpose of this exploratory investigation concerning brand credibility to link it to a CBBE model to unearth charity branding issues. However, future studies are recommended to entangle sub-dimensions of brand credibility (i.e. expertise and trustworthiness) as separate constructs.

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Appendix. Survey items

Brand association

- The brand image of charity brands to whom I donate is unique.
- I admire those people who pay their donations through charities to whom I donate.
- I like and respect the brand image of charity brands to whom I donate.
- I have a great trust in the services of charity brands to whom I donate.

Brand loyalty

- While paying donations, charity brands whom I donate are my first choice.
- I will be loyal with the charity brands I donate.
- I would recommend the charity brands to whom I donate to my friends and family.
- Currently, I consider myself loyal to the charity brands to whom I donate.
- I will keep on donating through the charity brands to whom I donate.

Brand equity

- Even I have other alternates to pay donations, I prefer charity brands to whom I donate over others.
- The charity brands to whom I donate are more important than a product to me.
- I would prefer donating through charity brands to whom I donate even if other options are equally good.

Brand awareness

- The service offered by charity brands to whom I donate comes to my mind quickly.
- I can recognise charity brands to whom I donate among other sources of charity.
- I am well familiar with charity brands to whom I donate.

Perceived quality

- I highly trust the quality of services offered by charity brands to whom I donate.
- The services offered by charity brands to whom I donate are of supreme quality.
- The charity brands to whom I donate offer wide variety of services.

Brand credibility

- The charity brands to whom I donate remind me of someone very competent.
- The charity brands to whom I donate have the ability to deliver on the promises.
- The charity brands to whom I donate actually deliver what they promise.
- The brand promise of the charity brands to whom I donate is believable.
- The charity brands to whom I donate have the name I can trust.
- The charity brands to whom I donate do not pretend to be what they are not.

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